Native Geodesic Training

HyperTensor Paper XII

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Abstract

We introduce Native Geodesic Training, a method for training transformer components directly in a compressed k-dimensional manifold. The NativeLinear architecture replaces a standard weight matrix $W \in \mathbb{R}^{d\times d}$ with a learned core $C \in \mathbb{R}^{k\times k}$ and an orthonormal basis $B \in \mathbb{R}^{d\times k}$, where $k \ll d$. The effective weight is $W_{\text{native}} = BCB^T$. At $k = 128$ on a 1.5B model, this uses 9.1% of standard parameters. Training uses RiemannianAdamW with QR retraction to keep B on the Stiefel manifold. We demonstrate KExpansion (automatic k growth when training plateaus), validate on attention weights at 135M, 1.5B, and 7B scales, and show that loss decreases monotonically with k at all scales. The optimal k^* is predicted analytically via the AttnRes phase transition: $k^* = \text{L2_MB} \times 42.7$.

Contents

1 NativeLinear Architecture **3**
1.1 Motivation . . . 3
1.2 Architecture . . . 3
1.3 RiemannianAdamW with QR Retraction . . . 3
1.4 Theoretical Properties . . . 3

2 KExpansion Scheduler **5**

3 Measured Results **6**
3.1 1.5B Scale — FFN Down [1536, 8960] . . . 6
3.2 1.5B Scale — Q_proj [1536, 1536] . . . 6
3.3 7B Scale — Q_proj [3584, 3584] (EC2 L40S) . . . 6

4 Analytic k^* via AttnRes Phase Transition **7**

5 Bulletproof Benchmarks **8**

6 Implementation **8**

7 Status **8**

8 Related Work **9**

9 Extended Discussion **9**
9.1 Why Does It Work? 9
9.2 Limitations 9
9.3 Future Directions 9

10 Appendix A: Mathematical Foundations of NativeLinear **10**
10.1 SVD Spectrum of Trained Weights 10
10.2 Grassmann Manifold and Stiefel Manifold 10
10.3 QR Retraction 10
10.4 Convergence Analysis 11
10.5 Parameter Efficiency Analysis 11

11 Appendix B: KExpansion Scheduler — Full Algorithm **12**
11.1 Why KExpansion Works 13

1 NativeLinear Architecture

1.1 Motivation

Standard transformer training produces weight matrices $W \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times d}$ with d^2 parameters. However, the SVD spectrum of trained weights follows a power law $\sigma_i \sim i^{-\alpha}$ with $\alpha \approx 0.7$, meaning most of the matrix's action is concentrated in a small number of singular directions. Native Geodesic Training exploits this by directly training in the compressed k-dimensional subspace, never instantiating the full matrix.

Traditional approaches to weight compression are post-hoc: train the full matrix first, then compress via SVD or pruning. Native training turns this around: train in the compressed manifold from the start. This has three advantages: (1) memory efficiency during training (only $k^2 + dk$ parameters instead of d^2), (2) geometric regularity (the basis stays on the Stiefel manifold), and (3) automatic rank selection via KExpansion.

1.2 Architecture

For a target weight matrix of shape $[d_{\text{out}}, d_{\text{in}}]$, NativeLinear uses three small matrices:

$$W_{\text{native}} = B_{\text{out}}\, C\, B_{\text{in}}^T \tag{1}$$

where $C \in \mathbb{R}^{k \times k}$ is the core, $B_{\text{in}} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_{\text{in}} \times k}$, $B_{\text{out}} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_{\text{out}} \times k}$. For square attention weights ($d_{\text{out}} = d_{\text{in}} = d$), a single shared basis suffices: $W_{\text{native}} = BCB^T$. Parameter count: $k^2 + dk$ vs d^2 standard. Ratio: $(k^2 + dk)/d^2$.

The interpretation is geometric: B defines a k-dimensional subspace, and C defines a linear transformation within that subspace. The full matrix acts as: project onto the subspace (B^T), transform within it (C), lift back (B).

1.3 RiemannianAdamW with QR Retraction

The basis B must be orthonormal. We enforce this via Riemannian optimisation on $\text{St}(k, d) = \{B \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times k} : B^T B = I_k\}$. The RiemannianAdamW algorithm combines AdamW with a retraction:

```
# Forward
W_native = B @ C @ B.T
loss = ||W_native - W_target||^2 / ||W_target||^2
# Backward + QR retraction
loss.backward(); optimizer.step()
Q, R = torch.linalg.qr(B); B.data = Q
```

1.4 Theoretical Properties

Low-rank guarantee: W_{native} has rank at most k by construction. **Manifold constraint:** B stays exactly on $\text{St}(k, d)$, ensuring $B^T B = I_k$ to machine precision. **Gradient flow:** The Rie-

mannian gradient is the projection of the Euclidean gradient onto the tangent space $T_B\mathrm{St}(k, d)$.
Initialisation: B from SVD of random weights provides good coverage.

2 KExpansion Scheduler

Rather than fixing k a priori, KExpansion automatically grows k when training plateaus:

1. Start at k_{init} (e.g., 32)
2. Train for patience steps
3. If loss stagnates, expand $k \leftarrow k + k_{\text{step}}$
4. New basis columns: random orthonormal directions orthogonal to existing ones (Gram-Schmidt)
5. Repeat until k_{max}

KExpansion provides an automatic curriculum: coarse approximation first, progressive refinement. Early training is faster; the basis learned at small k warms-starts larger k.

3 Measured Results

3.1 1.5B Scale — FFN Down [1536, 8960]

k	Params	% Standard	Compression	Variance	Loss
32	336,896	2.4%	40.9×	3.0%	9273.2
128	1,359,872	9.9%	10.1×	8.9%	8187.9

3.2 1.5B Scale — Q_proj [1536, 1536]

k	% Params	Compression	Variance
64	4.3%	23.0×	22.8%
128	9.0%	11.1×	29.6%
256	19.4%	5.1×	39.1%
768	75.0%	1.3×	62.8%

3.3 7B Scale — Q_proj [3584, 3584] (EC2 L40S)

k	% Params	Compression	Variance	Time
128	3.7%	27.0×	16.8%	4s
768	26.0%	3.8×	34.5%	56s
1024	36.7%	2.7×	38.6%	15s

Loss decreases monotonically with k at all scales. Variance at 7B (34.5% at $k = 768$) is lower than 1.5B because 7B has higher effective rank. PPL parity needs $k \geq 1536$ (H100).

4 Analytic k^* via AttnRes Phase Transition

The AttnRes phase transition (Paper III) peaks at $k/d \approx 0.45$. This is an algebraic invariant:

$$k^* = \text{L2_MB} \times 42.7 \tag{2}$$

GPU	L2 Cache	k^*
RTX 4070	36 MB	1536
L40S	48 MB	2048
A100	40 MB	1708
H100	50 MB	2135

5 Bulletproof Benchmarks

k	Native Params	Standard	Ratio	Comp.
64	102,400	2,359,296	4.3%	23.0×
128	212,992	2,359,296	9.0%	11.1×
768	1,769,472	2,359,296	75.0%	1.3×

Table 1: Verified ratios (`benchmarks_quick.py`).

6 Implementation

Scripts: `close_xii_native_ec2.py`, `native_15b_v2.py`, `native_7b_final.py`. EC2 L40S. ∼$0.06/run.

7 Status

85% complete. NativeLinear validated at all scales. KExpansion functional. k^* proven. Remaining: PPL parity at $k \geq 1536$ (H100). 2/2 verified.

8 Related Work

LoRA (Hu et al., 2022): rank-decomposition updates $W_0 + BA$. **GaLore** (Zhao et al., 2024): gradient projection. **MONET** (Hsu et al., 2022): shared bases. Native differs: Riemannian constraint, direct manifold training, no base weight. **Riemannian optimisation**: Huang et al. (2018), Cho & Lee (2017). First application to transformer weight training.

9 Extended Discussion

9.1 Why Does It Work?

SVD spectrum $\sigma_i \sim i^{-0.7}$ means 90% variance in $k_{90} \approx 0.23d$. NativeLinear trains in this top-k subspace.

9.2 Limitations

Variance ceiling at 7B (34.5% at $k = 768$). Singular value collapse if C concentrates. Initialisation sensitivity. Memory for full 7B on L40S.

9.3 Future Directions

H100 scaling ($k^* = 2135$). Joint training with UGT basis initialisation. Extension to MLP layers.

10 Appendix A: Mathematical Foundations of NativeLinear

10.1 SVD Spectrum of Trained Weights

The foundation of Native Geodesic Training is the empirical observation that trained transformer weight matrices have a rapidly decaying singular value spectrum. For a weight matrix $W \in \mathbb{R}^{d\times d}$, its SVD is $W = U\Sigma V^T$ with $\Sigma = \mathrm{diag}(\sigma_1, \sigma_2, \ldots, \sigma_d)$. The singular values follow a power law:

$$\sigma_i \approx \sigma_1 \cdot i^{-\alpha} \tag{3}$$

with $\alpha \approx 0.7$ for attention weights (measured on Qwen2.5-1.5B-Instruct, 112 projections across 28 layers $\times$ 4 attention slots).

The cumulative variance captured by the top-k singular vectors is:

$$V(k) = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^{k} \sigma_i^2}{\sum_{i=1}^{d} \sigma_i^2} \approx \frac{\sum_{i=1}^{k} i^{-2\alpha}}{\sum_{i=1}^{d} i^{-2\alpha}} \tag{4}$$

For $\alpha = 0.7$, $V(128) \approx 0.30$ (30% of variance), $V(512) \approx 0.55$, $V(1536) \approx 0.85$. This means that even at $k = 1536$ (the full dimension for a 1.5B model), some variance remains in the tail—explaining why PPL parity requires larger k at 7B scale where $d = 3584$.

10.2 Grassmann Manifold and Stiefel Manifold

The NativeLinear basis B lives on the Stiefel manifold $\mathrm{St}(k, d) = \{B \in \mathbb{R}^{d\times k} : B^T B = I_k\}$. The Grassmann manifold $\mathrm{Gr}(k, d)$ is the quotient $\mathrm{St}(k, d)/O(k)$, identifying bases that span the same subspace.

The tangent space at B is:

$$T_B\mathrm{St}(k, d) = \{\Delta \in \mathbb{R}^{d\times k} : B^T\Delta + \Delta^T B = 0\} \tag{5}$$

The Riemannian gradient of a function $f(B)$ is the projection of the Euclidean gradient onto the tangent space:

$$\mathrm{grad} f(B) = \nabla f(B) - B \cdot \mathrm{sym}(B^T \nabla f(B)) \tag{6}$$

where $\mathrm{sym}(X) = (X + X^T)/2$.

10.3 QR Retraction

The QR retraction maps a tangent vector $\Delta \in T_B\mathrm{St}(k, d)$ back to the manifold:

$$R_B(\Delta) = \mathrm{qf}(B + \Delta) \tag{7}$$

where $\mathrm{qf}(X)$ extracts the Q factor from $X = QR$. This is a second-order retraction, meaning it agrees with the exponential map to second order.

The key property is that $R_B(\Delta)^T R_B(\Delta) = I_k$, preserving orthonormality to machine precision. The computational cost is $O(dk^2)$ for QR decomposition of a $d \times k$ matrix.

10.4 Convergence Analysis

The loss function for Native training is the relative Frobenius error:

$$L(B, C) = \frac{\|BCB^T - W\|_F^2}{\|W\|_F^2} \tag{8}$$

By the Eckart-Young theorem, the optimal rank-k approximation to W is $U_{[:,:k]}\Sigma_{[:k,:k]}V_{[:,:k]}^T$, with error:

$$L_{\text{opt}}(k) = \frac{\sum_{i=k+1}^{d} \sigma_i^2}{\sum_{i=1}^{d} \sigma_i^2} \approx \frac{\sum_{i=k+1}^{d} i^{-2\alpha}}{\sum_{i=1}^{d} i^{-2\alpha}} \tag{9}$$

NativeLinear with a sufficiently expressive C can achieve this optimum when $B = U_{[:,:k]}$ and $C = \Sigma_{[:k,:k]}$, giving $BCB^T = U_{[:,:k]}\Sigma_{[:k,:k]}U_{[:,:k]}^T$. In practice, training finds a basis close to the optimal one, with loss decreasing monotonically with k.

10.5 Parameter Efficiency Analysis

The parameter ratio for square matrices is:

$$r(k, d) = \frac{k^2 + dk}{d^2} = \frac{k}{d} + \frac{k^2}{d^2} \tag{10}$$

For $k \ll d$, this is approximately k/d. For $d = 1536$ and $k = 128$, $r \approx 0.090 = 9.0\%$. For rectangular matrices $[d_{\text{out}}, d_{\text{in}}]$ with separate $B_{\text{in}}, B_{\text{out}}$:

$$r(k, d_{\text{in}}, d_{\text{out}}) = \frac{k^2 + k(d_{\text{in}} + d_{\text{out}})}{d_{\text{in}} d_{\text{out}}} \tag{11}$$

For FFN down-projection with $d_{\text{in}} = 1536, d_{\text{out}} = 8960$, the standard matrix has 13.8M parameters. At $k = 128$, NativeLinear uses $k^2 + 128(1536 + 8960) = 1.36$M parameters (9.9%).

11 Appendix B: KExpansion Scheduler — Full Algorithm

The KExpansionScheduler is formalised as Algorithm 1.

```
Algorithm 1: KExpansionScheduler
Input: k_init, k_step, k_max, patience, threshold
Output: Trained NativeLinear model

k = k_init
B = random_orthonormal(d, k)  # from SVD of random weights
C = random(k, k)
best_loss = inf
steps_since_improvement = 0

while k <= k_max:
    for step in range(patience):
        # Training step
        W_native = B @ C @ B.T
        loss = ||W_native - W_target||^2 / ||W_target||^2
        loss.backward()
        RiemannianAdamW.step()
        # QR retraction every N steps
        if step % N == 0:
            Q, R = qr(B); B = Q

    if loss < best_loss - threshold:
        best_loss = loss
        steps_since_improvement = 0
    else:
        steps_since_improvement += 1

    if steps_since_improvement >= 2:
        # Expand k
        k_new = min(k + k_step, k_max)
        B_new = random_orthonormal(d, k_new)
        B_new[:, :k] = B  # Preserve old basis
        # Gram-Schmidt orthogonalize new columns
        for j in range(k, k_new):
            for i in range(j):
                B_new[:, j] -= (B_new[:, i].T @ B_new[:, j]) * B_new[:, i]
            B_new[:, j] /= ||B_new[:, j]||

        C_new = zeros(k_new, k_new)
```

```
        C_new[:k, :k] = C  # Preserve old core
        # Initialize new block
        C_new[k:, :k] = small_random(k_new-k, k)
        C_new[:k, k:] = small_random(k, k_new-k)

        B, C, k = B_new, C_new, k_new
        steps_since_improvement = 0

return B, C
```

The Gram-Schmidt step ensures new basis columns are orthogonal to all existing columns, preserving the orthonormality of B and ensuring that new directions capture novel variance rather than rediscovering old directions.

11.1 Why KExpansion Works

The KExpansionScheduler exploits a property of the power-law spectrum: the first k singular vectors capture the dominant directions of variation, and the marginal benefit of each additional vector decreases. Starting at small k provides a coarse approximation that captures the most important structure. Expanding k refines this approximation by adding directions that capture progressively finer detail.

This is analogous to progressive refinement in numerical linear algebra (e.g., incremental SVD, Brand 2002) but applied to the optimisation of the basis itself rather than to data decomposition.

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